MONTHLY ARCHIVES: DECEMBER 2024

My Mom’s Frying Pan

My Mom’s Frying Pan

By Aadya Agarwal, grade 8, New Jersey.

They asked my mom, “What inspires you, Ms. Anne?”
Pat came her reply, “It sure is my frying pan.”
Her crisp reply left them confounded.
After all, she clearly left the Sun and the Moon grounded.

My mom was sure of her inspiration.
And this is what she offered as her explanation.

“Frying pan might look like a plain Jane tool.
But look! how, its emptiness itself makes it useful.
It tells me that nothing really belongs to you.
You are just a medium to pass things through.
You must clean yourself of the smallest residue.
So that you are ready to receive something new.”

“Frying pan has taught me to choose to be humble.
Go through and show up after every rough and tumble.
Seasoning through slow and high heating.
Strengthening through scratches and beating.
And not to suffer from any self-pity.
EN t you are where you are meant to be.”

Mom further said, “For me, frying pan is an unsung beauty,
That creates complex dishes through its simplicity,
And keeps my family fed by doing its duty.”

By Aadya Agarwal, grade 8, Princeton Day School, Princeton, New Jersey.

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Let's explore how to focus more attention on the ***root causes of what brings us health or what leads to disease***.

1. **What We Eat**: Looking around the world (especially, in the Blue Zones, where people are the healthiest and live the longest) the evidence points to eating a more unprocessed whole plant food diet as the healthiest choice. The healthiest diets incorporate fruits and vegetables, whole grains, legumes, and some nuts and seeds. Fiber in the food that allows our good bacteria (in our microbiome) to produce chemicals like butyrate (which decreases inflammation) and serotonin (that reduces anxiety and depression).

Did you know that FIBER is only found in plant foods? There is no fiber in animal foods. So, increasing the amount of whole plant foods in your diet will add to your overall health. To help you understand better the food choices and how to get a variety of plant foods in your diet, you might want to download the free app "Dr. Greger's Daily Dozen" on your smartphone. Or you might choose to do the free "21-day Vegan kickstart" program suggested by Physicians Committee for Responsible Medicine, PCRM. (Visit: www.pcrm.org). **The best evidence-based book** is How Not To Die, by Michael Greger MD.

2. **How We Move Throughout the Day**—or the lack of physical activity—is the fourth leading risk factor for global mortality. There are several types of exercises for us to consider:
    - *Aerobic/endurance exercise* (large muscles movement for sustained period)—lowers risk of all-cause mortality
    - *Strength or resistance exercise*—muscles contract against an external resistance—with the goal of increasing lean body mass and muscle strength and endurance
    - *Flexibility exercise*—range of motion that is possible at a joint
    - *Balance exercises*—static and/or dynamic exercises—decrease in falls and injuries like fractures

Any amount of activity is better than no activity. A physically active person engages in at least 150 minutes per week of moderate to vigorous physical activity. Moderate exercise elevates your heart rate but allows you to comfortably talk whereas vigorous exercise makes it difficult for you to speak more than a few words at a time due to increased [illegible]t. Sitting for prolonged periods of time leads to lessening of life expectancy.

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Keep your sitting times no longer than 50 to 60 minutes without a five-minute movement break. An excellent resource book on the benefits of exercise is: Spark, by John Ratey MD.

3. **The Chemicals We Choose to Consume**: Tobacco, alcohol, and street drugs continue to take a toll on our health. Prescription drugs, like opioids and side effects from other prescription drugs also exact a toll. Toxins from the not-regulated supplements and even plastic material (endocrine disruptors) found in foods like fish are potentially health damagers. The book Salt, Sugar, Fat: How the Food Giants Hooked Us, by Michael Moss is a good read to help your understanding about why we choose what we choose.
4. **How We Deal with Stress:** Stress can be helpful (if not overwhelming) or harmful. A stressor is a situation, circumstance, or stimulus that is perceived to be a threat. This threat alters homeostasis in the body.
   Categories of stressors: There are four types of streesors.

Psychological: thoughts, beliefs, or perceptions;
Physiological: illness, infection, disease, or hunger
Social: major life changes, personal conflicts, or financial insecurity
Bio-ecological: weather, pollution, food additives, or chemicals

- **Health effects of chronic stress:** Impaired immune function, inflammation, decreased bone density, problems with memory, increased appetite, weight gain, abdominal fat deposition, insulin resistance, increased glucose, cholesterol, and triglycerides, increased blood clotting, Impaired wound healing, poor sleep, pain and fatigue, poor mood, adoption of less healthy habits, decreased longevity (telomere shortening), and etiology of many chronic diseases, including hypertension, type 2 diabetes, and heart disease.
- **How to Manage the Pathological Stress Response:**
- **Breathing tools:** Lengthening exhale breath, Abdominal breathing
- **Movement:** Physical fitness, yoga, Tai chi, Qigong
- **Meditation**
- **Connecting with Nature**
- **Self-expression:** Playing a musical instrument, singing, creating art, or dancing
- **Community Engagement:** Volunteering for meaningful causes, quality time with family and friends, spiritual or religious activities
- **Reading** self-help books and websites

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- **Massage**
- **Listening to music**
- **Light therapy**
- **Mental health and Nutrition:** Fried foods, refined grains, and sugary products are associated with increased rates of major depression and anxiety disorders, A plant-based dietary pattern with no meat, fish, or eggs in a randomized, controlled trial showed a significant improvement in depression symptoms in just two weeks. Fruit and vegetable consumption has been associated with improvement in depression, anxiety, higher productivity, and higher optimism.

  A wonderful resource book to get started in this area is: The Mayo Clinic Guide to Stress-Free Living, by Amit Sood MD

5. How we sleep: Average sleep is 7 hours a day, but 20% adults sleep less than 6 hours. Short sleep duration has increased in all age groups. 60 million people in U.S. have frequent difficulty sleeping (but only 10% seek professional help)

- **Indirect costs of Insomnia:** Presenteeism (people at work but not productive), Increased risk of long term disability, Mistakes, errors, and accidents
- There is no recognized objective test for how much sleep a person needs
- Healthy sleep duration and quality as well as circadian physiology promote improved health; Lower cortisol and glucose levels, greater insulin sensitivity, higher daytime leptin and reduced food-seeking behaviors, lower sympathetic tone, greater nighttime peripheral perfusion, increased stamina and faster cardiovascular recovery time.

  A Recommended Resource: Why We Sleep by Matthew Walker, PhD is a very good book resource on this topic.

6. Our Social Connections: A Harvard study concluded that our relationships matter! Our relationships and how happy we are in those relationships has a powerful influence on our health. Taking care of your body is important but tending to your relationships is a form of self-care also. Childhood nurturing plays a significant role in midlife thriving. Marital happiness and social connectedness moderate our health and happiness.

- **Social Networks:** Being part of a social network improves longevity
- **Positive Psychology Interventions**
  ur blessings everyday (e.g. thinking of three things you are thankful for)
  Expressing gratitude and appreciation (e.g. what challenges did you manage this week?)

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Savoring the pleasant things in life (e.g. taking five minutes a day to savor a particular activity)
Writing down how we want to be remembered (I want people to remember me for…)
Connecting and interacting with others regularly in person, not solely or mainly through social media (Belonging to family, social groups, sport groups, spiritual groups, etc.)
Regularly practicing acts of kindness (how do you feel afterward?)
Doing activities that feel meaningful (Reflect on what makes this activity meaningful)
Thinking of one's happiest days frequently (Look at photos and think about emotions experienced)
A Recommended Resource: Together by Vivek Murthy MD is one of the best reads on social connection.

If you have an interest in learning more about any of the above these six pillars of health, feel free to connect with me at cataniaross@msn.com. I am retired medical practitioner, and I do not charge to help you along on your journey toward improved health.

Wishing you the very best of health to you in 2025 and beyond,

By Charlie Ross DO, DipABLM. Certified Lifestyle Medicine Physician, Osteopathic Medical Practitioner. Website: www.livelifestylemedicine.com

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Art by Leicie Tonouchi, Age 14, Hawaii

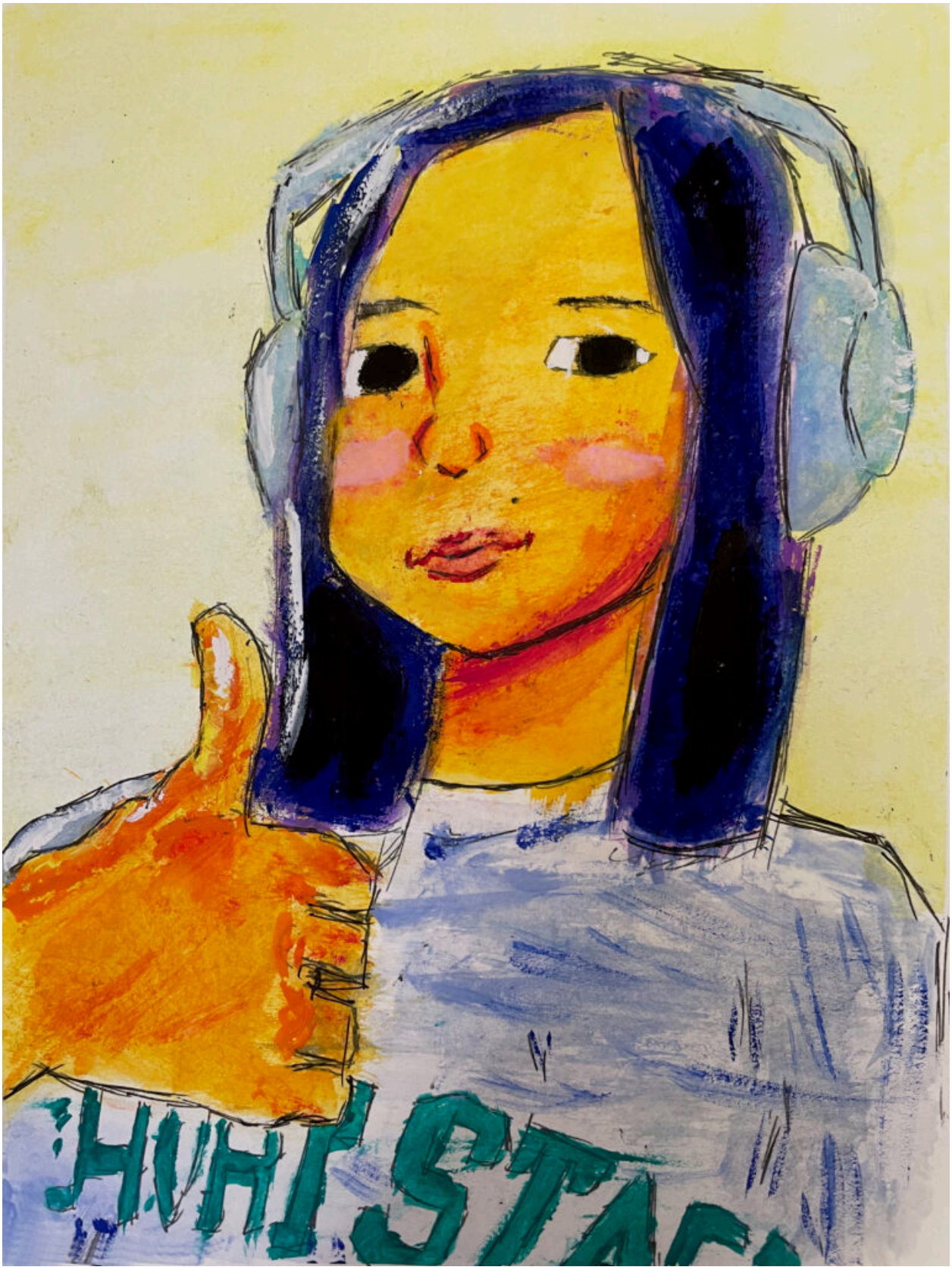
Art by Leicie Tonouchi, Age 14, Hawaii

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“Keila is too cool for school. I painted Keila in ink and gouache.”

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“Cassie has positive vibes. I painted Cassie in ink and gouache.”

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"This is my interpretation of the classical Okinawan story called "The Legend of the Shisa." I drew this digitally using Procreate."

The Legend of the Shisa

Retold by Leicie Tonouchi, Age 14, Hawaii.

A long time ago in Okinawa, Japan, the villagers were partying at the beach when out of nowhere they saw something big—a serpent from the sea!

The serpent began to terrorize the village. One of the villagers looked at the Shisa (Okinawan lion dog) statue and prayed for help and miraculously the Shisa statue became alive! The Shisa battled the serpent and chased it back into the ocean. The villagers cheered as their homes had been saved. When everyone was safe, the Shisa turned back into a statue again. This is why in every home in Okinawa, people have two Shisa statues in each household. A male Shisa with an open mouth to scare away the evil spirits and a female Shisa with a closed mouth to keep in the good energy.

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Hazel Lee, Chinese American Fighter Plane Pilot

Hazel Lee, Chinese American Fighter Plane Pilot

By Fanny Wong, New York

"Race you to the corner!" Hazel challenged the boys.

The boys groaned, but maybe, just maybe, they could beat her this time.

They didn't. Beaten again by this scrawny young girl. She also played handball and cards with them. Guess who won?

Hazel's parents, immigrants from China, met and married in Portland, Oregon. Hazel, the third of eight children, lived with her family in Portland's Chinatown. It was the only community the Chinese were allowed. The children went to Chinese school on Saturdays to learn to their language and culture.

Hazel was good at writing and speaking Chinese, but a traditional Chinese girl she wasn't. Her voice was too loud, her laughter too boisterous. She was handy and fixed things around the house. Not ladylike at all.

When Hazel was a teenager, a friend took her up in a biplane at an air show. Her eyes danced, face flushed, and her heart raced with excitement as the plane lifted off. The rumbling motor and whirring propellers were music to her ears. She was as free as a bird high up in the sky. Hazel's dream soared with the plane. She knew she belonged in the cockpit of a plane.

Now that she had a dream, she had to find a way to make it come true.

First, she had to find a job after graduating from high school in 1930. The only job she could find was as an elevator operator in Liebes department store in downtown Portland. Up and down she took customers from floor to floor. She stuck to the boring job her job to r flying lessons.

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Hazel's parents turned pale when she enrolled in a flight school in 1931. It was not what a woman did. It was not what a young Chinese woman did. What would the Chinese community think of their daughter!

"You're not afraid of the water, you're not afraid of the wind!" her mother lamented. It was her way of saying Hazel was not scared of anything. Eventually, her parents let her try something different, be someone different from what the Chinese community expected of her.

Hazel went through the same training as the men at the Chinese Aviation School in Portland. The mind-boggling controls, dials and levers did not intimidate her. She lived for the moment when the plane swooped like a swallow over sea and land. The higher the plane soared, the freer she was.

Hazel passed all the flight tests in a year and received her pilot license in 1932. At that time, only one percent of American pilots were women. In those days, people thought a woman should not fly a plane. How could a woman handle an emergency? Too emotional! Too nervous! And whoever heard of a Chinese female pilot? Hazel couldn't find a pilot job.

In response to Japanese aggression against China in 1932, Hazel journeyed to China, hoping to join the Chinese Air Force. But again, she was frustrated that it did not accept women pilots. In the end, she settled in Canton and flew for a private airline.

After returning to the United States in 1938, Hazel waited for years before she could prove herself. In 1942, during WWII, when male pilots fought overseas, the military needed more pilots at home. Some 25,000 women applied for the program. In 1943, with 35 hours of flying time and a medical exam, Hazel was one of 1097 women pilots accepted by the new Women Airforce Service Pilots Program (WASP) to prove their skills.

Like the other trainees, Hazel had to pay her way to Sweetwater, Texas for training. Their pay was $259 a month, with no benefits. She was among the select few and the only Chinese. For six months, in the dusty and hot Avenger Airfield, she endured sand in her hair, snakes and spiders even indoors. But she learned to fly different military airplanes, parachuting and making emergency landings. She studied all the parts of the plane, rudder [illegible] struts. When she learned to take apart the engine and put it back together, [illegible] proud as if she had won a trophy.

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One time, Hazel's instructor made an unexpected loop. Her seat belt did not work properly. She fell out and parachuted safely. On the ground, she dragged the parachute behind her all the way back to the airfield. The incident didn't faze her.

Another time, Hazel's plane's engine cut out in mid-flight. She made an emergency landing in a wheat field in Kansas. A farmer chased her, thinking the Japanese had invaded Kansas. She convinced him that she was flying in a U.S. flight program. Hazel knew no matter how American she was she would be looked at differently. But this incident did not discourage her. No, she might look like the enemy, but she was thoroughly American.

Easy-going Hazel made many friends. At 31, she was eight to ten years older than the rest of her classmates. They soon forgot she looked different, that she was the only Chinese they knew. Her calm, fearless piloting skills impressed them. They loved her irrepressible sense of fun, as when she wrote their nicknames in Chinese on their planes with lipstick. Her personality bubbled over like a pot of soup. Her friends knew she was nearby when they heard her laugh, "Heeyah! Heeyah!"

Although Hazel graduated from the WASP program in 1943, the U. S. Government did not allow women in combat roles at the time. Instead, being one of the best graduates, she was chosen for Pursuit School at Brownsville, Texas. There, she trained with 134 other graduates to fly fighter planes, such as the Pursuit and the P-51 Mustang, high powered single-engine jet planes. After the training, she delivered the new planes from factories to airfields all over the North America. If anything was wrong with them, she was among the first to know.

Hazel accepted dangerous missions, such as flying in open cockpit planes in the winter, shivering in many layers of clothing. Another dangerous job was flying a plane that served as a "tow." A large target sleeve was attached behind her plane for gunners to practice shooting from the ground. She cringed when bullets whizzed by the cockpit, but she kept flying these dangerous flights. Sometimes, after the practice flight, she found holes in the tail of the plane.

Hazel crisscrossed the country in wartime to deliver planes that would be used in combat. She flew seven days a week, bone-tired, but proud of her non-combat role in wartime and [illegible]llenge in strides.

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As Hazel zoomed cross the sky, she wished her Chinese community could see her in an un-conventional job, and doing it well!

On Thanksgiving Day, 1944, Hazel delivered a plane-a P-36 King Cobra from Niagara Falls, New York to Great Falls, Montana. As her lane approached the airfield, a plane above her lost radio control reception. The pilot did not know the position of Hazel's plane. The two planes collided and burst into flames. The other pilot had non-life-threatening injuries., but Hazel died of her wounds two days later.

Because the WASPs flew military planes as civilians, they received no military benefits. Hazel's family had to pay for her remains to be shipped home. After resistance from the River View Cemetery in Portland to bury a Chinese person there, Hazel's family sought help from an Oregon senator, who appealed to the White House. The cemetery relented and Hazel was buried in a gentle grassy slope. Her grave marker was a polished slab of red granite with a winged diamond etched above her name, a symbol of the silver WASP wings pinned on the uniforms of American women who flew in WWII.

In 2004, the State of Oregon inducted Hazel into the Aviation Hall of Honor. Hazel and the other WASP pilots would not be recognized with military status until 1979. In 2009, President Obama awarded surviving and deceased pilots the Congressional Gold Medals.

Comfortable in a career dominated by men, Hazel not only lived her dream but proved a woman could fly a fighter plane as well as any man. She didn't expect to make history. As the first Chinese American women to fly for the U. S. military, she was doing what she loved, for a country she loved.

—Fanny Wong, Chinese American Author, New York. She is a frequent contributor to Skipping Stones Magazine.

HHR's 2024 Essay, Art & Multimedia Contest Winners

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Hindus for Human Rights and *Skipping Stones* announce the 2024 Essay, Art & Multimedia Contest Winners!

This year's contest invited students in grades 6-12 to explore the inspiring traditions of peacemaking in South Asia and its diaspora. We asked young writers and artists to reflect on the question, "As a South Asian, what traditions of peacemaking do you find inspiring?"

Violence and conflict have long been a part of South Asian and South Asian diaspora history, literature, and storytelling, but so have different versions of peacemaking. The contest invited students to take inspiration from any South Asian history, literature, poetry, peace activists, or peace movements that focus on concepts or ways to address peace, justice, and democracy.

The contest received a diverse array of essays, artwork, and multimedia submissions showcasing a wide range of South Asian histories, movements, and traditions that advocate for harmony, justice, and democracy. These submissions were heartfelt, creative, and thought-provoking, demonstrating the power of young voices in envisioning a more peaceful world.

Our Hearty Congratulations to all the winners!

Essay Winners:

* 1st Place: **"With Andal Comes Grace"** by Lekha Kolli, grade 12, Virginia.
* 2nd Place: **Anti-Sikh Riots and Ongoing Traditions of Peacemaking** by Ira Tiwari, grade 11, Illinois.
* 3rd Place: **"South Asian Peace Through the Millennia"** by Jacob Sajan, grade 11, Arizona.

Art & Multimedia Winners:

* 1st Place: **Narrated Bharatanatyam Performance** by Deekshitha Jayaprakash, grade, 11 Minnesota. (Please click on the link to view the performance!)
* 2nd Place: **Flowers of Peace Illustration** by Aniya Taneja, grade 12, Massachusetts.
* 2nd Place: **Bangladesh Protests** by Eshita Lahiry, grade 11, Louisiana.
* 3rd Place: Drawing inspired by the **10,000 for World Peace Assembly** by Diya Lane, grade 12, California.

Download the **Winning Entries** *(This is a 5 MB file)* by clicking **here!**

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The 2024 Essay & Art Contest on Civil and Human Rights

We are pleased to present the winners of the Third Annual Essay and Art & Multimedia Contest on Civil and Human Rights. This national contest was sponsored by *Hindus for Human Rights* and *Dalit Solidarity Forum.* The 2024 theme was about **Inspiring Traditions of Peacemaking in South Asia.**

Essay Winners:

* First Place: "**With Andal Comes Grace**," *by Lekha Kolli, grade 12, Virginia.*
* Second Place: **Anti-Sikh Riots and Ongoing Traditions of Peacemaking**, *by Ira Tiwari, grade 11, Illinois.*
* Third Place: "**South Asian Peace Through the Millennia**" *by Jacob Sajan, grade 11, Arizona.*

Art & Multimedia Winners:

* First Place: **Narrated Bharatanatyam Performance** *by Deekshitha Jayaprakash, grade, 11 Minnesota.*
* Second Place: **Flowers of Peace**, *by Aniya Taneja, grade 12, Massachusetts.*
* Second Place: **Bangladesh Protests**, *by Eshita Lahiry, grade 11, Louisiana.*
* Third Place: Drawing inspired by the **10,000 for World Peace Assembly** *by Diya Lane, grade 12, California.*

Our Hearty Congratulations to all the Winners!

The First Place winner, **Narrated Bharatanatyam Performance**, *can be viewed by clicking the link provided earlier.*

Second Place Art & Multimedia Winner: "Flowers of Peace" *by Aniya Taneja, grade 12, Massachusetts.*



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First Place Winner: With Andal Comes Grace

By Lekha Kolli, Grade 12, Virginia.

The rich cultural tapestry of South India, with its deep-rooted spiritual and communal traditions, has always inspired me. Two traditions, the Bhakti movement and ***Kudiyirkkal***, offer profound insights into how peace, justice, and social harmony can be cultivated in our world. My journey of understanding these traditions has been deeply personal, shaped by the teaching of Andal, the celebrated female poet of the Alvar tradition of Tamil Bhakti. Her vision of divine love, where grace flows like the incarnation of Bhumi Devi, the goddess of Earth, has ignited a desire to contribute to a world where people live with grace and extend peace and justice to all.

Andal is the embodiment of divine grace and equality. Andal's poetry has resonated with me on a deeply personal and spiritual level. Her devotion to Lord Vishnu is not just an expression of personal faith but a call to her entire community to rise above societal divisions and embrace a shared spiritual identity. In her book Tiruppavi, Andal invites everyone, regardless of their background, to partake in the celebration of divine love. This inclusivity and her vision of the world where divine grace is accessible to all have profoundly influenced my understanding of peace and justice.

When I think of Andal, I imagine a world where people treat one another with the same grace that she believed was embodied by Bhumi Devi. Bhumi Devi acts as a companion Vishnu, representing patience, tolerance, and unyielding commitment to nurturing life. Andal's devotion to Vishnu, as seen through her hymns, reflects a yearning for a world where humanity recognizes and honors the divine in each other. This vision inspires me to see the divine in every person, to approach conflicts with empathy, and to seek resolutions that uplift rather than divide.

The Bhakti movement is a pathway to peace through spiritual devotion, focusing on personal devotion and spiritual egalitarianism, which offers a vivid framework for fostering peace in society. Challenging rigid social structures of their time, as poet-saint Andal did, and advocating for a direct, personal relationship with the divine that transcends class and caste is revolutionary. Revolutionary in that the movement honored its simplicity; it emphasized that love and devotion to God were more important than rituals or social caste.

For me, the Bhakti movement, like the words of Andal's poetic teachings, represents how spiritual devotion can be a unified force. In a world often divided by caste, religion, and social barriers, the Bhakti tradition's message, from saints like Andal, of universal love and equality is timeless and relevant. It inspires me to approach life with a spirit of devotion not just to the divine, but also to the well-being of humanity. By focusing on what unites us rather than what divides us, the Bhakti movement offers a pathway to peace grounded in the shared human experience of love and longing for the divine.

A community-centered conflict resolution practice that inspires me is ***Kudiyirkkal***, the traditional way of communal mediation in southern India. This practice, rooted in the belief that conflicts should be resolved within the community through dialogue and consensus, embodies a deeply humane approach to justice. Unlike modern legal systems that often emphasize punishment, ***Kudiyirkkal*** seeks to restore harmony by addressing the root causes of conflict and repairing relationships.

Growing up in a world where justice is often equated with retribution, I find the principles of ***Kudiyirkkal*** to be refreshingly compassionate. It teaches that true justice is not about winning or losing but about a solution that honors dignity above all. This approach to conflict resolution resonates with my belief in the power of grace. Just as Andal's vision of Bhumi Devi emboding patience and compassion, ***Kudiyirkkal*** shows us that peace is achieved not through force, but through understanding and reconciliation.

Inspired by Andal's poetry and the traditions of the Bhakti movement and ***Kudiyirkkal,*** I have cultivated a vision where grace, peace, and justice are not just visions, but lived realities. In this vision, people extend grace to one another, just as Bhumi Devi nurtures all life on Earth. Conflicts are approached with empathy and resolved through dialogue, as practiced in ***Kudiyirkkal***. And, like the Bhakti tradition saints, we recognize the divine in each other, breaking down barriers of caste, class, and creed to create a more just and equitable society.

continued on p. 3 >>>

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Second Place: Anti-Sikh Riots, Sufi traditions, and Ongoing Traditions of Peacemaking

By Ira Tiwari, Grade 11, Illinois.

Reflecting on my heritage and ancestry, I often find myself at the crossroads of history, where beautiful poems of peace clash with sorrowful cries of violence. A particular tale lingers in the crevices of my mind, tucked behind every thought, action, and decision. This tale is our heritage, a second shadow that follows us even in complete darkness.

This shadow is the memory of the 1984 anti-Sikh Riots, also known as the Sikh genocide. This chapter in India's history looms large, casting a long shadow over the country. It's a tug-of-war between tranquility and chaos.

Two years ago, I found myself scrolling through Netflix, desperate for something to watch. My eyes landed on *Jogi*. Immediately, I pressed *Play*. An hour into the film, I found myself curled up on the couch, clutching my blanket tightly as a shield. My father entered the room and inquired about what I was watching. When I told him, he responded with a casual, "Oh, I remember." Puzzled, I replied, "The movie just came out." He shook his head, "No, not the movie, the riot." At that moment, the atmosphere in the room shifted. This wasn't just a film anymore; it was his story.

He began recounting that year when he was a young boy living in Bokaro. My father and his family huddled inside their home as chaos erupted outside. They clung to their faith, burning *agarbatti* (an incense stick) in hopes that the smoke would ward off evil. The smoke outside told a different story. It billowed from the burning homes of their Sikh neighbors, lifelong friends with whom they had shared cups of chai and laughter. Now, these friends were running for their lives, their livelihoods, their homes, their families all engulfed by these flames.

Inside their home, my father's family remained silent, their house sealed like a sanctuary. The only sounds that disturbed the quiet were the muffled prayers that flowed from their lips. "We couldn't do anything but pray," my father recalled. They prayed for safety, for peace, and for their Sikh friends' survival as violence turned their once vibrant neighborhood into a wounded landscape. Outside, peace had vanished, but inside, the flickering flame of a *diya* kept a corner of their world illuminated. They hoped the flickering flame in the *diya* was enough to counter the hungry flames outside.

When the violence subsided, my father's family ventured outside to survey the damage. The destruction was brutal. The stores and homes of their Sikh friends lay in ruins, reduced to ashes. The community was left broken and battered, with men burned and beaten to death, and women raped, left defenseless. The thick, long hair of the dead, matted with blood, lay tangled in the debris where once their turbans had proudly sat. The air hung heavy with despair disguised as soot, a silent cry for peace that had gone unheard amid the chaos.

Yet, amidst the devastation, traditions of peace persisted. Sufi songs and bhajans floated through the streets, each hum, each verse combating the sharp notes of the sobs. My grandfather, like many others, visited grieving Sikh families, offering whatever support he could. He shared tiffins with those who had lost everything. A way of offering peace when none seemed to be left. The community responded in kind. Mosques opened their doors, offering *langar* (community meals) to the Sikhs, just as Sikhs had done before. These acts of compassion; providing food, shelter, and solace stood stark in contrast to the violence, proving that amidst destruction, the tradition of finding peace could endure.

With Andal Comes Grace... *continued*

This is not just a dream but a guiding principle in my life. It influences how I interact with others, how I approach challenges, and how I think about my role in the world. Andal's legacy, along with the teachings of the Bhakti movement and ***Kudiyirkkal***, reminds me that peace and justice start with each of us. By embodying grace in our daily lives and striving to see the divine in others, we can contribute to a world where peace and justice are available to all.

In a time when the world is increasingly divided, these South Indian traditions offer timeless wisdom on how to live with grace and foster peace and justice in our communities and beyond. They inspire me to be not just a believer in these ideals, but an active participant in making them a reality.

—Lekha Kolli, Grade 12, Virginia.

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The image my father painted, of his nearest and dearest losing everything in days, haunts me. Yet, serves as inspiration. The stories of how they were able to go from nothing to rebuilding everything echoes resilience. The women left with nothing, not a husband, not a home, found the courage to restart, driven by the children in their care. The men who remained collected the rubble from their homes and businesses, putting them back together piece by piece. The *mandirs,* mosques, and *gurdwaras* turned to homes for people rather than gods. These stories of rebuilding are what I hold closest. The daily rituals of South Asia, whether it's the burning of *agarbatti*, the lighting of *diyas*, or the serving of langar are more than cultural practices. They are acts of resistance against hate, tangible symbols of a deep-rooted belief that good can counter evil and peace can prevail.

Reflecting on this story, I realize that these traditions of peace-making aren't relics of the past. They are living practices that shape South Asia and its diaspora today. In recent times, we have witnessed the rise of social movements that draw from this well of peaceful resistance. From the farmers' protests in India to global climate strikes, these movements echo the same spirit of nonviolence. Emulsed in a history of violence, South Asian peace-making glimmers through the cracks, serving as continuous inspiration on a global scale.

The lessons of 1984 remain relevant, in a world where polarization is rising. The stories of people risking their lives to protect others, of communities coming together to support those in need remind us that peace isn't passive. It's active and intentional.

Today, I find myself doing as my father, his friends, and family had clutching on to peace even when the world around me suggests otherwise. The tradition of peace-making isn't just about grand gestures; it's about the small, everyday actions that, when taken together, can generate a force strong enough to counter the greatest acts of violence.

That day I decided to light *agarbatti* after conversing with my father. I prayed as a being without a religion, for the strength to find peace in the midst of chaos. I prayed for the courage to be like those before me, to protect, to nurture, to rebuild, and to find peace. In the end, peace isn't just the absence of violence. It's the presence of love, community, and hope. That's the tradition I choose to carry forward.

By Ira Tiwari, grade 11, Illinois.

Resources and References:

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Third Place Winner: South Asian Peace Through the Millennia, *By Jacob Sajan, Grade 11, Arizona.*

I'm a South Asian, an Indian to be exact. While I was born in the United States, my parents and brother were all born in India before immigrating here. Even here, so far from the life and culture of my family, where most Americans still view India as a poor, hungry, third-world country, the name of one Indian leader is held in the highest regard. At the risk of sounding cliché, I'd like to talk about Mahatma Gandhi. Rather than stop there, though, I want to delve into the rich history that helped Gandhi lead what would become the role model for nonviolent movements across the world. While Gandhi was an extraordinary man, his philosophy was nothing revolutionary. The idea of nonviolence is deeply embedded into South Asian culture, ingrained into the history of our land through the impact of not just one, but three important leaders that have advanced the movement over the millennia.

In 261 BCE, Emperor Ashoka of the Mauryan Empire waged war against the kingdom of Kalinga, resulting in a war that took between 100,000 to 250,000 lives. Walking among the corpses in the aftermath of the battle, Emperor Ashoka was shaken by overwhelming horror at what he had just done. From that moment, he vowed "to conquer mankind through people's hearts and not through war." In the *Military History of Odisha*, scholar Ramesh Prasad Malhotra wrote, "No wars in the annals of human history have changed the heart of the victor from one of wanton cruelty to that of exemplary piety as this one." The violent, dominating legacy the Mauryan empire had cultivated over the previous 100 years took a drastic turn with Ashoka. He converted to Buddhism in the aftermath of the war and advocated for its peaceful ideals, such as *ahimsa* (nonviolence), *metta* (loving-kindness towards all), and numerous others. This age-old story inspires me so deeply, because it shows that even the most greedy, violent individuals can turn into peaceful people when faced with our powerful nonviolent culture. Regardless of your worldview, there is probably at least one leader who you see as a brutal tyrant, but our history shows us that even those leaders can become calm, peaceful Ashokas. Ashoka carved many pillars and edicts out of rock known as the Ashokan Edicts to spread nonviolence, which served as the foundation upon which the nonviolent movement would be built. Even here, over 2,000 years ago, we can see our first powerful individual who left a lasting impact on the nonviolent movement.

Centuries later, we find our second impactful individual, Emperor Akbar of the Mughal Empire, whose reign lasted from 1556 CE to 1605 CE. Often called Akbar the Great for his intelligent reforms, Akbar made various changes to balance a power disparity older than the Mughal Empire itself. The Muslim minority had ruled over the Hindu majority for centuries in the Indian subcontinent, the power discrepancy dating all the way back to the Delhi Sultanate established in the 13th century. To combat this, Akbar abolished the jizya. Until Akbar's time, non-Muslims had always been forced to pay a head tax, called the jizya, the refusal of which would result in harsh punishments, from house arrest to enslavement. Akbar also appointed many Hindu officials into the government and military, amplifying Hindu influence. Akbar even tried to synthesize the many religions within his empire into the *Din-i Ilahi*, Akbar's own religious movement. While unsuccessful in gathering followers, the attempt alone is a testament to Akbar's zeal to reduce the violence in his empire. I personally love this story because it shows that it only took one person to undo centuries of injustice. Granted, that one person in this case was an emperor, but we too are the emperors of our spaces, and we can make change around us, no matter how deeply rooted the problem is. Akbar's reforms were the tower upon which Gandhi would promote his peacemaking ideals, built on Ashoka's foundation. Gandhi fought for a unified India, with all religions living at peace with one another in the same country, and though the area was eventually split into India and Pakistan against Gandhi's will, it's certain that the disagreeable terms on which they separated would have been much worse had Akbar not built interreligious peace centuries prior.

This journey of 2,000 years is what preceded Gandhi's nonviolent movement in India. While Gandhi was no trailblazer, there is no doubt he took the nonviolent movement to new heights. If Ashoka was the foundation and Akbar was the tower, Gandhi was the beacon at the top of the lighthouse, shining the nonviolent movement's light across the world. We so often

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South Asian Peace Through the Millennia, continued from p. 5

forget the aftermath of Gandhi's campaign, though. We all know of the many civil rights movements across the world inspired by Gandhi, but the original nonviolent movement in South Asia itself found a new face in the Non-Aligned Movement. In the midst of the Cold War, India led many countries around the world in forming the Non-Aligned Movement, where countries could find solace in not supporting either side. Among the 120 countries still in the organization, every single South Asian country is listed.

It is clear to me that though our history may not be the prettiest, we have held an ideal of peacekeeping for millennia. Our methods have varied over time, but it is evident that Gandhi's ideas weren't unknown to our land. What Gandhi really did was stand at the top of the lighthouse thousands of years in the making and call us to our nonviolent roots, just as our forefathers Ashoka, Akbar, and many others have done throughout history. These traditions inspire me since we so often look at history as a tapestry of brutal bloodshed and injustice, a lesson of what never to repeat again, but when viewed through a positive lens, we can also find what our ancestors did right and learn what we can emulate.

By Jacob Sajan, Grade 11, Arizona.



Second Place: **Bangladesh Protests** *by Eshita Lahiry, Grade 11, Louisiana.*

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2024 Art & Multimedia Winners; Art Descriptions

***Second Place*: Aniya's Art** *(p. 1)* "As a South Asian, I've been shaped by the principles of good and bad karma. The Hindu culture promotes respect, especially towards one's elders, and kindness as fundamental virtues to display towards everyone. However, above all, I've been raised to show appreciation and worship towards every living thing. Whether it be the plants that consistently nourish our bodies, the animals we've depended on for centuries, or the tranquility we find when all five senses engage with nature, the Earth has been a vital part of our culture and wellbeing for centuries.

As a flower enthusiast, the use of flowers in our culture is the tradition of peacemaking that I find most inspiring. We consider flowers a gift, bringing them into our homes for their beautiful scents, appealing colors, and vibrant presence. Although simple and in abundance, we consider them as symbols of love, devotion, and hope. We give flowers meaning—having a significant place in our festivals, celebrations, and prayers. In my eyes, the shared love and harmony people find in flowers is what makes life so vibrant. Without first learning to revere every little thing, how do we learn to respect each other? Being able to find and share the color in the little parts of nature is essential to finding peace and connection in a world continuously burdened by troubling news. For me, the most inspiring tradition of peacemaking is something I find just outside my home, yet something I can share anywhere I go."

***Second Place:* Eshita's Art** *(p. 6)* "The Artist Vincent van Gogh once said that there is peace even in the storm. As an artist, I believe that peacemaking can exist amidst conflict and violence in South Asia. There have always been traditions of peacemaking unique to South Asia. In my piece, I have explored the tradition I believe to be the most prominent: nonviolent grassroots movements. To explore these movements, I chose two monumental moments in Bangladesh's history that I believe have best expressed the impact nonviolent movements had on history: the March 7, 1971 speech by *Bangabandhu* Sheikh Mujibar Rahman and the student quota protests of 2024 in Bangladesh. Although years apart, both events express how collective actions grounded in peace can transform societies.

Delivered during a critical moment in Bangladesh, *Bangabandhu*'s speech was the unifying call that brought Bengalis of all faiths and backgrounds to stand against oppression. His speech showed the power words and negotiations have in rallying a movement without resorting to violence. Similarly, the recent student quota protests in Bangladesh showcased how peaceful protesting can lead to meaningful change. These students, united by a shared vision of justice, put aside their differences and employed nonviolent tactics, such as banners and posters, to demand reform of the civil service. Their success was a testament to the power of peaceful protesting to bring social justice and reform. Although I could have portrayed other events, these movements are important to me because I am Bengali. I draw inspiration from these movements to remind myself that there are still individuals willing to set aside their differences and unite for the same cause. They represent collective actions that offer amicable, yet impactful, ways to establish peace without resorting to violence."

3rd Place: Diya Lane's Art Inspired by the 10,000 for World Peace Assembly *(p. 8)*

Description: "The peacemaking movement that inspired my art piece was the '10,000 for World Piece Assembly' hosted by Transcendental Meditation in India. During this event, several thousands from not just India, but from over 139 different countries, joined together to meditate despite the turbulence of the world. My artwork depicts a diverse group of people gathered together with closed eyes in meditation.

Growing up in an Indian household meant growing up with meditation. Every morning I would wake up to my *Nani* and my mom doing yoga, and then meditating before starting their days. As a kid, the concept of sitting still for minutes (or hours) confused me, but as I got older and began to experience the stress, frustration, and difficulty of life, I learned to appreciate the stillness of meditation. It became an escape from the chaos of the world and gave me a chance to reconnect with myself, even if only for a few short minutes. Meditation has helped me through some of the most difficult, and turbulent times in my own life. The 10,000 for World Peace Assembly represented peace in its most natural, raw form, and in a world where obtaining peace feels like an uphill battle never won, this movement proved that there is peace in the world for everyone waiting within themselves."

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Third Place: **Drawing inspired by the 10,000 for World Peace Assembly**
by Diya Lane, Grade 12, California.

The 2024 contest winners were recognized during a national zoom gathering organized by the Hindus for Human Rights and Dalit Solidarity Forum.
We invite your entries for the 2025 contest. Visit the contests page of ***Hindus for Human Rights'*** website for rules and deadlines.

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Resources for GAZA Issue

More About the Contributors

The following organizations and cultural projects are mentioned in this collection. We encourage you to check them out and offer support where your heart is inclined.

Meera Center for Skills Development in Cairo offers learning and enrichment activities for Gazan refugees. From 2011-23, Wejdan Diab directed the award-winning Meera Kindergarten in Gaza City. She now offers a nurturing space in Cairo, where children can learn, play and heal from the trauma of the war. **Donate here to support Meera Center.**

Palestine Charity Team (PCT) is a 501c3 nonprofit organization providing humanitarian aid to families in Rafah, Gaza. PCT sponsored Sing to Live in Peace, a children's music program, and the Gaza Heartbeat, a creative writing workshop for older youth. Currently, PCT is focusing on getting food aid into southern Gaza and setting up portable classrooms and activities for children. **Donate to PCT.** More original music by Bakr Khader is available on YouTube.

Sobhi Qouta, from Gaza City, is an art teacher for students of all ages. IDF airstrikes destroyed his studio and all its art, including the student paintings featured in this issue. To help Sobhi rebuild his studio, please contact **Fred Rogers**.

Abraham's Land, a musical play, by guest editor Lauren Goldman Marshall, is set in Israel and Gaza during the First Intifada. A video of the 2021 professional production was shown by PCT in Gaza and is available on YouTube.

You can read the Special Issue on Palestine and Israel, published online by ***Skipping Stones*.**

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There is a wealth of charitable organizations serving Palestinians. Here are some of our favorite organizations you may not have heard of:

A Land for All envisions a binational solution (two states, one homeland) with Jewish majority and Palestinian majority regions, freedom of movement and right of return for all.

The Humanity Project:The Maal Foundation serves a wide variety of needs of Gazan refugees in Cairo, including financial support, medical care, psychological and educational support.

The Leonard Education Organization (LE.O) supports under-resourced Palestinian students with higher educational opportunities. Donate to LE.O or to the special fund for Gazan medical students in Egypt, or the In the Wings scholarship for a student from Gaza to study in the arts.

Middle East Children's Alliance protects the health, lives, and rights of kids in the Middle East.

Interlink Publishing offers a wide selection of books on Palestine.

International Board on Books for Young People – Palestine Section and Gaza Libraries project

Tomorrow's Women empowers Palestinian and Israeli women to make peaceful change.

Community Peacemaker Teams (CPT) – Palestine supports Palestinian-led, nonviolent, grassroots resistance against the Israeli occupation.

ANAR is an important project for traumatized children living in the West Bank.

The Liberation Syllabus for Educators by the progressive Jewish organization If Not Now lists books, poetry, films, art, and music for students of all ages to engage with the reality of the occupation.

Standing Together is a progressive grassroots movement mobilizing Jewish and Palestinian citizens of Israel against the occupation for peace, equality and social justice.

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